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Match Chapter 3's final Kiri geometry, then use a non-POV editorial match cut into the flashback.

PANEL 2

Top-left narrow close-up: Naruto's ordinary three-tomoe Sharingan fills the panel; the EMS is inactive. The pupil match-cuts editorially—not as a thought or memory cue—into a black sewer opening at the left edge. No text.

PANEL 1

Top-right horizontal strip: Present-day Kiri, matching Chapter 3's ending. Naruto stands on the right facing left; Jiraiya is a soft foreground shoulder on the left facing right. Kakashi, Sasuke, and Yugao stay small behind Jiraiya on the left. Naruto's eye-line meets Jiraiya's, but he gives no answer. His gunbai remains on his back and the plain sash sword is visibly equipped at his left hip. If the narrow strip crops below the hilt, state in the image prompt that the camera hides the sword but Naruto remains equipped with it. No text.

PANEL 3

Middle full-width panel: Flashback Naruto enters the inner sewer from the right and walks left; his reflected steps lead the eye toward the unseen cage. Reserve clean dark-wall negative space at upper-left for the exact chapter marker. CAPTION in a small upper-right box, no tail: "ABOUT ONE YEAR AFTER NARUTO LEFT KONOHA." SFX low in the water behind his heel: "STEP." TITLE in that safe upper-left negative space: "CHAPTER 4 — THE OPEN CAGE".

PANEL 4

Dominant bottom panel: The gate spans the left two-thirds. The Nine-Tails lies behind it with his head on his paws, facing right. Naruto stops small at lower-right, facing left. B1 at upper-right, tail to Naruto: "HELLO, KYŪBI." B2 at upper-left, tail threading through the bars to the Nine-Tails: "WHAT DO YOU WANT?"

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State the requested exchange and expose the history that makes it unacceptable.

PANEL 2

Top-left medium: Naruto at reader-right faces left, arms folded. The gate bars remain visible along the left border. B2 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "I WANT TO OFFER YOU SOMETHING." B3 upper-left, same tail path: "IN RETURN, I WANT SOMETHING FROM YOU."

PANEL 1

Top-right close-up: The Nine-Tails' near eye opens, aimed down-right at Naruto. B1 upper-right, tail through the bars to the Nine-Tails: "MAKE IT QUICK."

PANEL 4

Middle-left wide: Naruto holds the Nine-Tails' eye-line without advancing. B5 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "IF I GIVE YOU YOUR FREEDOM, COME WHEN I CALL."

PANEL 3

Middle-right inset: The Nine-Tails' muzzle behind one bar. B4 upper-right, tail to the Nine-Tails: "WHAT?"

PANEL 5

Dominant bottom panel: The Nine-Tails raises his head; bars divide his face while Naruto remains a small silhouette at lower-right. B6 upper-right, tail to the Nine-Tails: "MY FREEDOM—FOR ANOTHER SHARINGAN TO CONTROL ME?" B7 upper-left, same speaker and tail: "I WOULD RATHER STAY HERE."

Let distrust press Naruto's claim instead of letting him explain uncontested.

PANEL 2

Top-left close-up: The Nine-Tails' lip lifts over one fang. B2 upper-left, tail through the bars to the Nine-Tails: "HUMANS SAY ONE THING." B3 immediately below and connected to B2, sharing B2's tail to the Nine-Tails: "THEN THEY DO ANOTHER."

PANEL 1

Top-right close-up: Naruto, still reader-right and facing left. B1 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "I NEVER SAID I WOULD CONTROL YOU."

PANEL 4

Middle-left medium: Naruto's hand lowers; the Nine-Tails watches from behind the bars. B5 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU KNOW I COULD FORCE YOU."

PANEL 3

Middle-right medium: Naruto lifts two fingers toward his own Sharingan but does not activate any technique. B4 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU LIVE INSIDE MY BODY."

PANEL 6

Bottom-left medium: Naruto stays motionless with deliberate empty space between him and the gate. B6 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "I HAVE NOT." B7 upper-left, connected to B6 and sharing B6's tail to Naruto: "CONTROL IS BENEATH ME."

PANEL 5

Bottom-right narrow reaction: The Nine-Tails' eye narrows. No text.

Turn a failed negotiation into an irreversible gift.

PANEL 2

Top-left close-up: The Nine-Tails' stare hardens. B2 upper-right, tail entering from the right to off-panel Naruto: "BUT YOUR HATRED IS MAKING YOUR CHOICES FOR YOU."

PANEL 1

Top-right medium: Naruto looks up at the Nine-Tails, eye-line left and upward. B1 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "I DO NOT BELIEVE YOU ARE A MINDLESS BEAST."

PANEL 3

Middle full-width panel: The Nine-Tails rises behind the gate and leans right; his tails flare across the left background. Naruto does not step back. B3 upper-left, tail to the Nine-Tails: "IF THIS CAGE WERE OPEN, I WOULD TEAR YOU APART."

PANEL 6

Dominant lower-left panel: Naruto walks into the right-side darkness, back to the Nine-Tails; the open water between him and the barred beast is the image. B6 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "IT DOES NOT MATTER." B7 upper-middle, connected to B6 and sharing B6's single visible tail to Naruto: "YOU WILL STILL HAVE YOUR FREEDOM." B8 upper-left, connected to B7 as the final continuation and explicitly inheriting the B6-B7 stack's same single shared tail to Naruto: "I WILL RETURN IN TWO DAYS."

PANEL 5

Lower-middle small panel: Naruto takes one step right, away from the cage. B5 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "I ASKED FOR YOUR HELP TO MAKE YOU LISTEN."

PANEL 4

Lower-right small panel: Naruto turns his shoulders toward the sewer exit on the right but looks back left. B4 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU WOULD RATHER I LIED?"

Make the extraction plan legible before inner and outer spaces begin intercutting.

PANEL 1

Top full-width, half-page-height establishing panel: Dragon Land is a Fire-Forest-like wilderness broken by active volcanic vents. Medium-specific basalt terraces descend from right to left beneath an invented ash-red sky; Naruto and joined Zetsu are small at centre-right. CAPTION upper-right, no tail: **"TWO DAYS LATER — ANCIENT LAND OF DRAGONS."**

PANEL 3

Middle-left medium: Zetsu holds Naruto's eye-line. B2 upper-left, tail to Zetsu's joined mouth: **"I PULL THE NINE-TAILS OUT FROM HERE."**

PANEL 2

Middle-right medium: Physical Naruto kneels at centre-right facing left. Joined Zetsu crouches left of him, facing right. B1 upper-right, tail to Naruto: **"I WILL WEAKEN MINATO'S SEAL FROM INSIDE."**

PANEL 5

Bottom-left wide: Naruto closes his eyes while Zetsu braces one knee against the basalt to his left. The caldera slopes carry the eye left. B4 upper-right, tail to Zetsu: **"AND IF THE SEAL HOLDS?"** B5 upper-left, tail to Naruto: **"WE BREAK IT."**

PANEL 4

Bottom-right medium: Naruto places one hand over his abdomen. B3 upper-right, tail to Naruto: **"THE KYŪBI PUSHES FROM THE OTHER SIDE."**

Begin the three-part action in the order Naruto specified.

PANEL 2

Top-left narrow, physical world: Zetsu waits left of Naruto's kneeling body. This physical panel is silent. No text.

PANEL 1

Top-right medium, inner world: Naruto reappears visibly at reader-right facing the gate. The Nine-Tails stands behind it on the left. B1 upper-right, tail to the visible inner Naruto: "I WILL WEAKEN THE SEAL." B2 upper-left, connected to B1 and inheriting the stack's single shared visible tail to inner Naruto: "ZETSU WILL PULL FROM OUTSIDE."

PANEL 3

Middle full-width, inner world: The Nine-Tails leans right into the bars; Naruto points once toward him. B3 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU FORCE YOURSELF OUT."

PANEL 6

Dominant bottom-left panel, inner world: The seal ink liquefies and runs downward as orange chakra leaks rightward through the bars toward Naruto. The Nine-Tails' eye opens wider at reader-left; Naruto winces at lower-right. SFX low and thin beside the right-moving chakra: "HSSSS."

PANEL 5

Bottom-middle close-up, inner world: His hand turns clockwise; his body twists with the resistance. SFX curved around the formula: "CRK."

PANEL 4

Bottom-right close-up, inner world: The black seal formula appears across Naruto's exposed abdomen. His chakra-lit fingers press into its centre. SFX beside the fingers: "THRUM."

Connect leaked chakra to Zetsu's pull and make the simultaneous strain readable.

PANEL 2

Top-left close-up: Liquid-black formula slides across Naruto's pale abdomen; an orange thread pushes through its centre. SFX beside the thread: "HSSSS."

PANEL 1

Top-right diagonal: Physical Naruto pitches left from his knees. Zetsu catches his shoulders from the left before his head hits basalt. No text.

PANEL 3

Middle full-width panel: Zetsu plants his right palm on the seal, catches the orange thread, and draws it left. His left hand forms and maintains a one-handed seal. B1 upper-left, tail to Zetsu: "I HAVE IT."

PANEL 5

Dominant bottom-left, physical world: The orange tether stretches from Naruto at centre-right to Zetsu's pulling hand at centre-left. Zetsu leans left; Naruto's body arches right against the force. SFX written along the tether: "THRUM."

PANEL 4

Bottom-right inset, inner world: Gate bars bow toward the right as the Nine-Tails drives his shoulder into them from the left. Naruto braces at lower-right. No text.

Bring Naruto to the final lock and end before revealing what stops him.

PANEL 2

Top-left narrow: The Nine-Tails pushes right again, claws dug into the floor behind the bars. No text.

PANEL 1

Top-right narrow, inner world: Naruto is down on one knee at reader-right, breathing through pain. The gate shudders at left. No text.

PANEL 3

Middle full-width, physical world: Zetsu continues pulling left; the chakra tether is thicker, but the Nine-Tails has not emerged outside. Naruto remains conscious with eyes shut. No text.

PANEL 5

Dominant bottom-left close-up: An unidentified man's bare hand clamps around Naruto's wrist before the paper comes free. Show only the hand, a plain sleeve cropped before any identifying cuff, Naruto's arrested fingers, and half-lifted paper—no face, hair, symbol, silhouette, or name. The dash in "RRRIP—" visually terminates at the gripping hand. No balloon.

PANEL 4

Bottom-right medium, inner world: Naruto rises to the paper seal and closes his right hand on its lower edge. The Nine-Tails watches from the left, still pushing. SFX beside the lifting corner: "RRRIP—"

Reveal Minato and let all three characters identify the relationship differently.

PANEL 1

Large upper panel, no more than 45% page height: The previously unidentified hand is now identified as Minato's. Minato stands centre-right holding Naruto's wrist and has pushed him down-right, away from the paper. The Nine-Tails remains behind the closed gate on the left and has stopped pushing to glare right at Minato. B1 high upper-left, local to the Nine-Tails with one short visible tail through the nearby bars: "YONDAIME." B2 lower upper-right, local to Minato with one short visible tail to him: "NARUTO?" The higher placement makes B1 read first; neither tail crosses the panel or another balloon.

PANEL 4

Bottom-left close-up: The Nine-Tails bares his teeth. B5 upper-left, tail to the Nine-Tails: "I WILL TEAR YOU APART."

PANEL 3

Bottom-middle close-up: The Nine-Tails' muzzle presses near the bars, eye-line hard right. B4 upper-left, tail to the Nine-Tails: "COME CLOSER."

PANEL 2

Bottom-right close-up: Naruto looks up-right at Minato with surprise already controlled. Minato remains visible at the left edge and visibly winces when Naruto uses his name. B3 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "HELLO, MINATO."

End Minato's interruption without expanding it into the later father-son conversation.

PANEL 2

Top-left close-up: Naruto stands. B2 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "IT DOES NOT CONCERN YOU."

PANEL 1

Top-right two-shot: Minato releases Naruto's wrist. They face one another on the right side of the cage axis; Minato looks down-left, Naruto up-right. B1 upper-right, tail to Minato: "WHY ARE YOU BREAKING THE SEAL?"

PANEL 3

Middle full-width: Minato steps left to block Naruto's path back to the paper; the bars remain behind him. B3 upper-right, tail to Minato: "I CAN'T LET YOU FREE THE NINE-TAILS." B4 upper-left, connected to B3 and sharing B3's tail to Minato: "IT'S DANGEROUS—"

PANEL 5

Bottom-middle close-up: Minato looks at Naruto; Naruto's hand begins to emit a flat, outward pulse. B6 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU ARE DEAD." B7 upper-left, connected to B6 and sharing B6's tail to Naruto: "YOUR ROLE IS FINISHED."

PANEL 4

Bottom-right medium: Naruto steps inside Minato's reach and places his open right palm against Minato's chest. B5 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "YOU ARE CHAKRA LEFT INSIDE A SEAL."

PANEL 6

Dominant bottom-left panel: Naruto drives the pulse left through Minato. Minato dissolves into pale fragments without a body, soul, or Edo Tensei corpse remaining. The Nine-Tails watches through the bars behind the fragments. B8 upper-right, tail to Naruto: "DISAPPEAR, MINATO." SFX among the fragments: "FSHH."